合肥大學
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Frequency Fitness Assignment as a Research Direction

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Outline



1. Introduction
2. Research Field: Optimization
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Introduction

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- My students and I are members of the Optimization Direction.
- Today, I therefore want to first give a short introduction into the field of optimization, before delving into one of our concrete research topics, namely Frequency Fitness Assignment (FFA).

Research Field: Optimization



What is Optimization?

- There are two ways to look at optimization.



What is Optimization?

- The economic view.

Optimization Problem

An optimization problem is a situation which requires deciding for one choice from a set of possible alternatives in order to reach a predefined or required benefit at minimal costs.

What is Optimization?

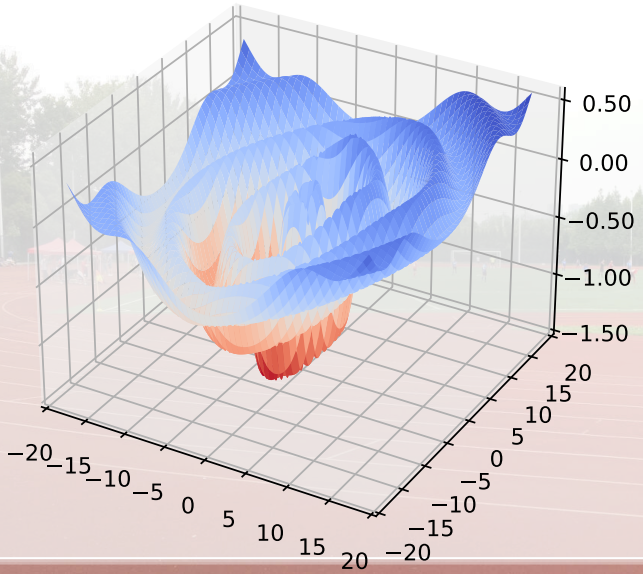
- The mathematical view.

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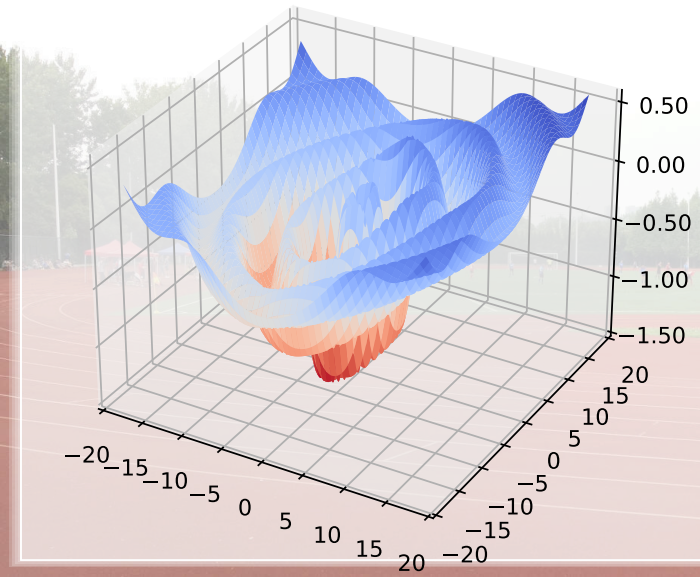
Solving an optimization problem requires finding an input element $x^\star$ within a set $\mathbb{X}$ of allowed elements for which a mathematical function $f\colon \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ takes on the smallest possible value.

Example: Function Optimization



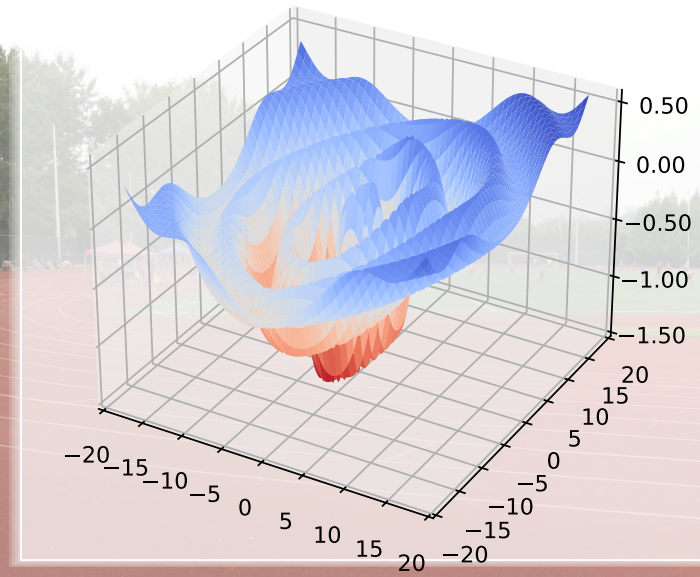
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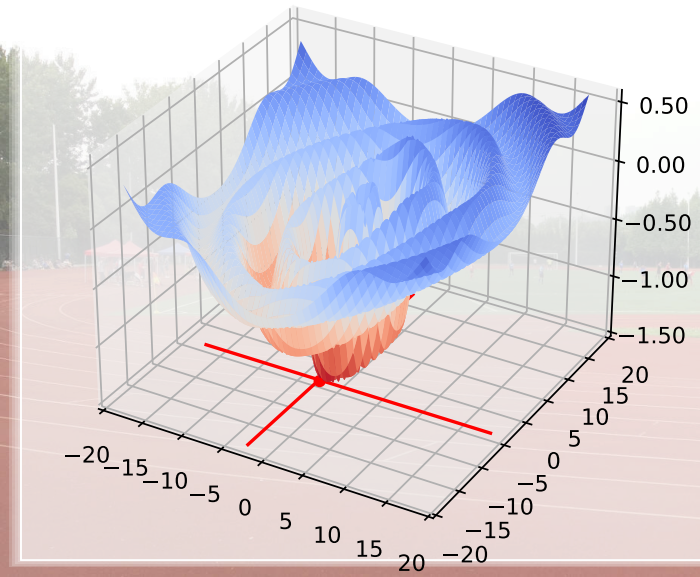
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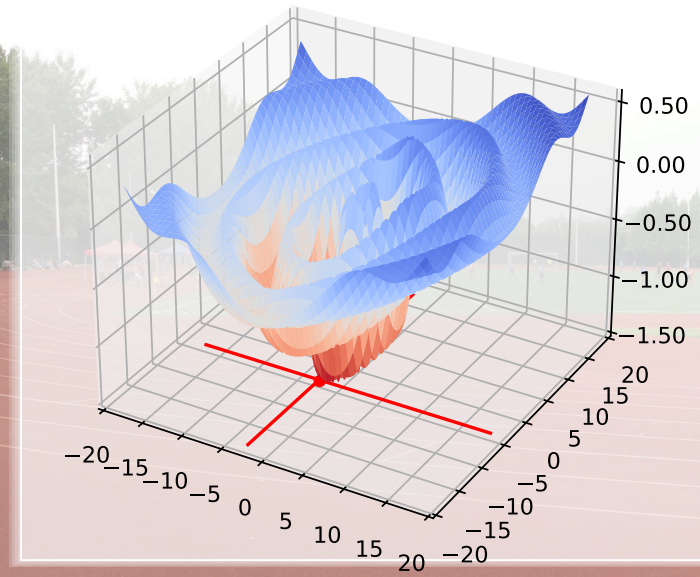
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- This is *not* what I am working on, though.

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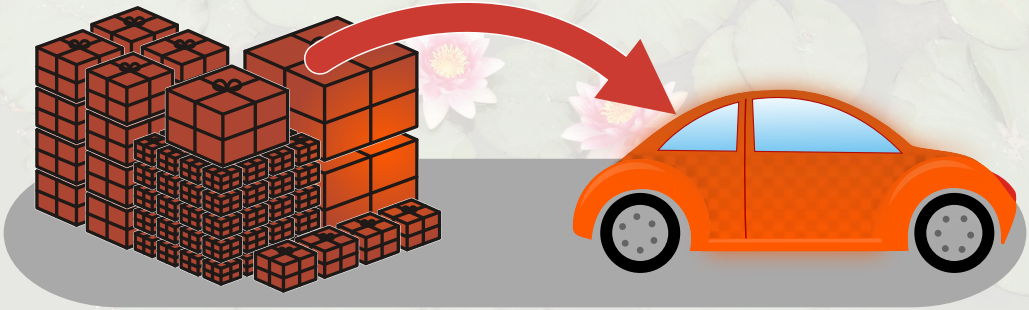
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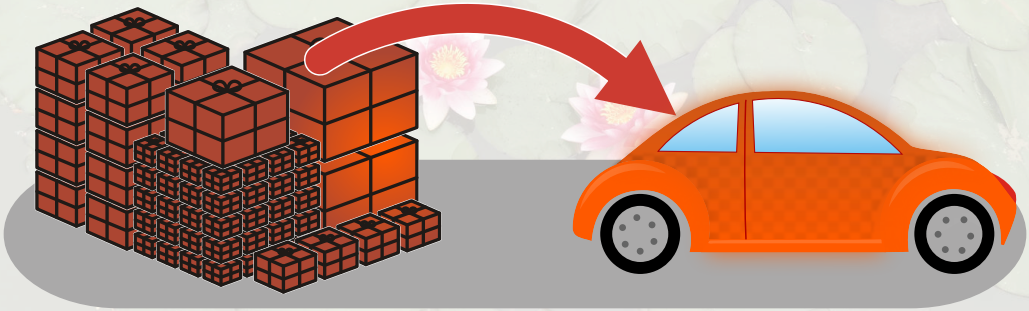
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- The goal of the Bin Packing Problem is to pack n objects, each having a specific size, into as few bins (also of a given size) as possible[226,227].



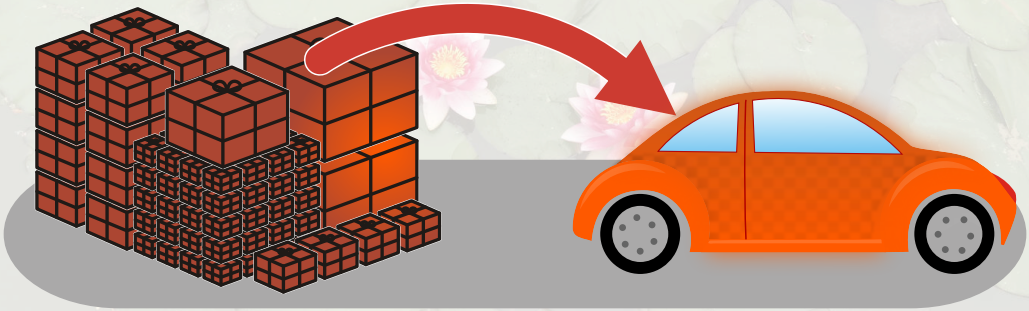
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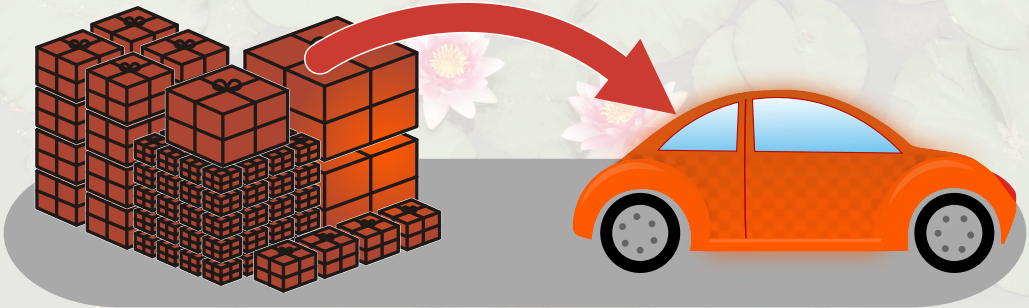
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- The optimum $x^\star$ is the packing order requiring the fewest bins.



Optimization is Hard



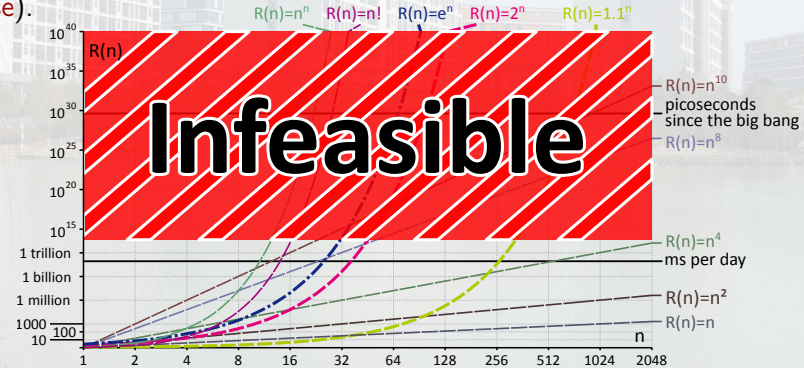
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- In other words, if we want to guarantee to find the best possible solution $x^\star$ for all possible instances of a problem, we often cannot really be much faster than testing all possible candidate solutions $x \in \mathbb{X}$ in the worst case.

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Begin with a set $S_0 \subset \mathbb{X}$ of one or multiple randomly sampled solutions

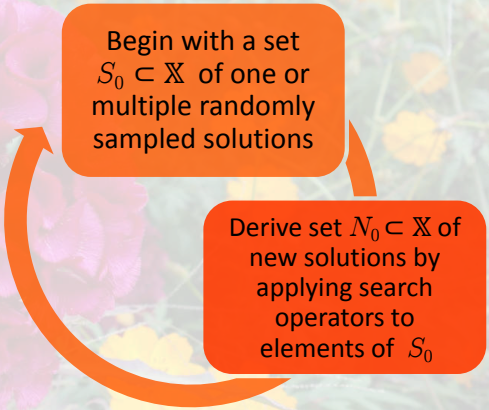
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- And then roughly follow this cycle.



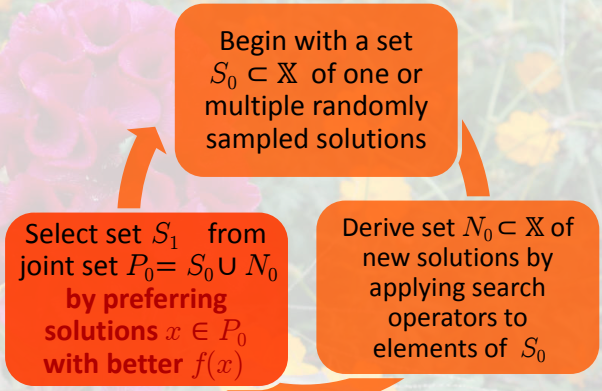
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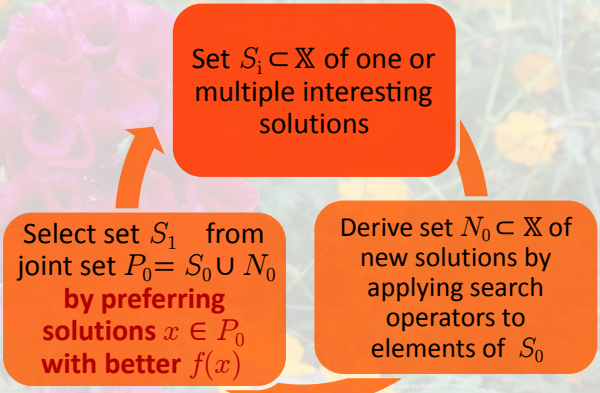
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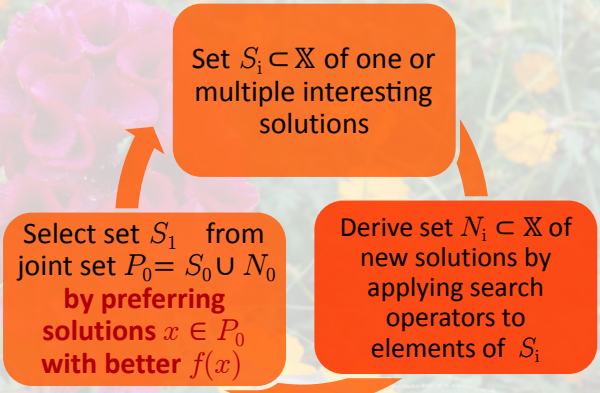
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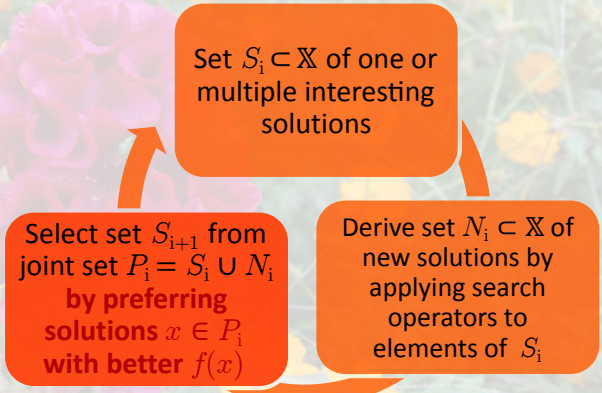
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  return x_c, y_c

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- Let's start with RLS/$(1+1)$ EA and modify it to become SA.

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    if $\mathfrak{R}_0^1 < e^{y_c - y_n}$ **then**
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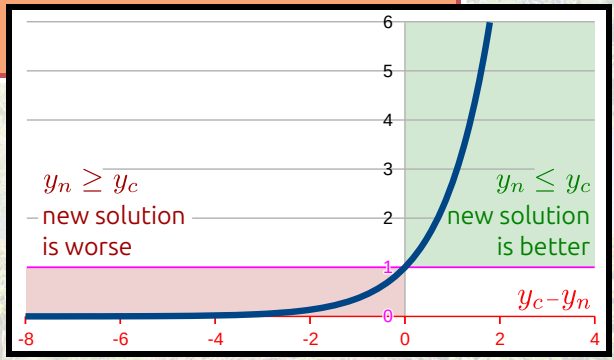
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- P is regulated by temperature schedule with parameter T_0.

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- Simulated Annealing (SA)[115] is a local search that accepts also worsening moves, but with a probability that decreases over time and with the difference in solution quality.
- $\mathfrak{R}_0^1$ be a random number uniformly distributed in $[0, 1)$.
- High temperatures T increase the acceptance probability P of worse solutions, low T reduce it.
- P is regulated by temperature schedule with parameter T_0.

procedure SA($f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$, T_0, ε)
  randomly sample x_c from $\mathbb{X}$; $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$;

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  while ¬ terminate **do**
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  randomly sample x_c from $\mathbb{X}$; $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$;
  $x_B \leftarrow x_c$; $y_B \leftarrow y_c$; ▷ preserve best!
  $\tau \leftarrow 0$; ▷ τ is iteration counter
  while ¬ terminate **do**
    $x_n \leftarrow \texttt{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;
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Begin with a set $S_0 \subset \mathbb{X}$ of one or multiple randomly sampled solutions

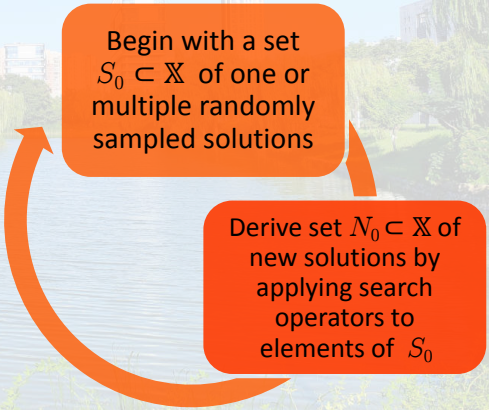
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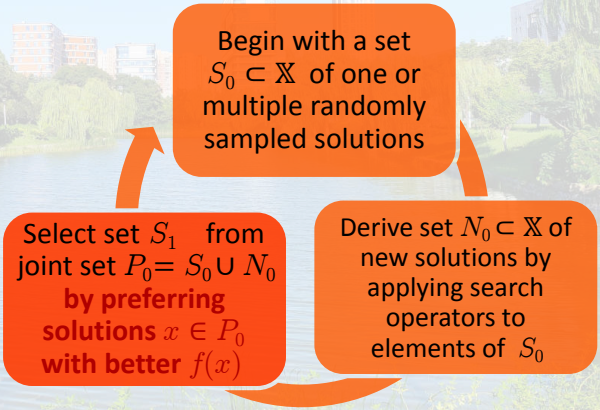
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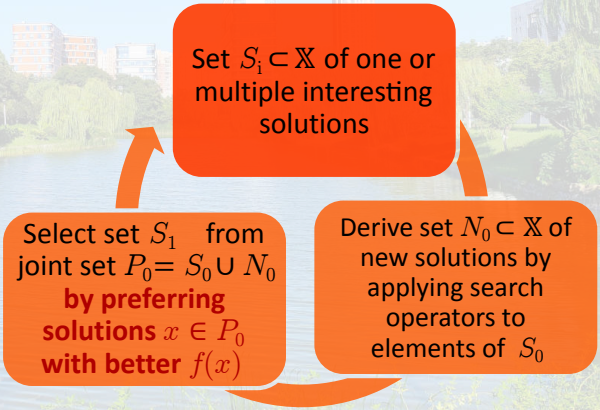
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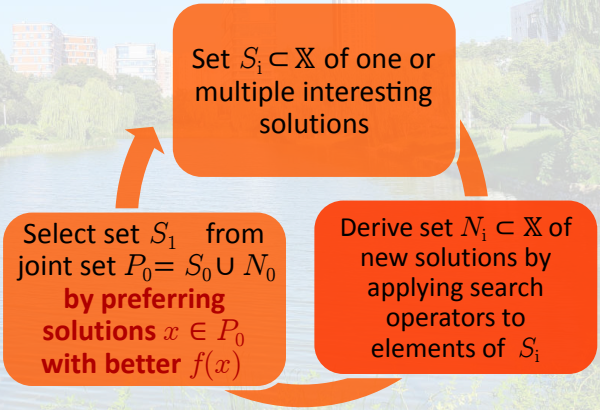
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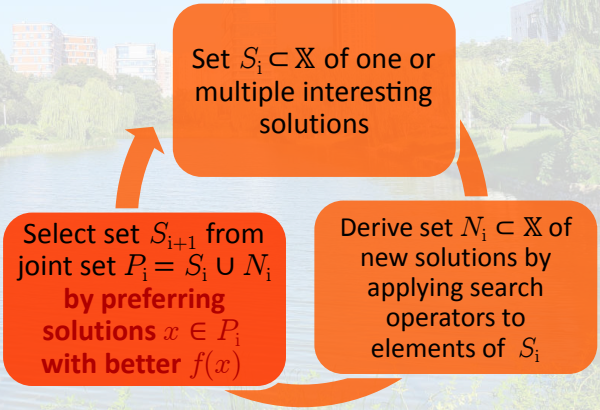
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- We investigate classical hard problems that have discrete search spaces, such as bit strings or permutations.
- Here, the objective functions take on only natural numbers in $\mathbb{N}_0$.
- We try to enable metaheuristic algorithms to find better solutions for these problems.

Research Direction: Frequency Fitness Assignment



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- We challenge this principle.
- Our Frequency Fitness Assignment (FFA) does **not** prefer better solutions ... yet it can improve the performance of existing algorithms in several cases!

FFA: Idea



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- The table H is initially filled with zeros.
- Before the selection step of the algorithm, $H[f(P_i[j])]$ for all $j \in 1..|P_i|$ is incremented by 1.
- Then, the frequencies $H[f(P_i[j])]$ replace the objective values $f(P_i[j])$ in the actual selection decisions.

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA

- Let's plug FFA into the $(1+1)$ EA and obtain the $(1+1)$ EA with FFA ($(1+1)$ FEA).

procedure $(1+1)$ EA$(f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R})$
  randomly sample x_c from $\mathbb{X}$; $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$;
  while $\neg$ terminate **do**
    $x_n \leftarrow \texttt{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;
    if $y_n \leq y_c$ **then** $x_c \leftarrow x_n$; $y_c \leftarrow y_n$;
  return x_c, y_c

FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA

- We start with the $(1+1)$ EA.

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- We begin by initializing the frequency table H with all zeros.

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  $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \cdots, 0)$;
  randomly sample x_c from $\mathbb{X}$; $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$;

  while $\neg$ terminate **do**
    $x_n \leftarrow \texttt{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;

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- *Before* the selection decision, we increment the frequency values of the objective values of all current solutions.

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  while $\neg$ terminate **do**
    $x_n \leftarrow \texttt{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;
    $H[y_c] \leftarrow H[y_c] + 1$; $H[y_n] \leftarrow H[y_n] + 1$;
    if $y_n \leq y_c$ **then**
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- Now the frequency values replace the objective values in the selection decisions.

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procedure $(1+1)$ FEA$(f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{N})$
  $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \cdots, 0)$;
  randomly sample x_c from $\mathbb{X}$; $y_c \leftarrow f(x_c)$;

  while $\neg$ terminate **do**
    $x_n \leftarrow \texttt{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;
    $H[y_c] \leftarrow H[y_c] + 1$; $H[y_n] \leftarrow H[y_n] + 1$;
    if $H[y_n] \leq H[y_c]$ **then**
      $x_c \leftarrow x_n$; $y_c \leftarrow y_n$;

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FFA: (1+1) EA and (1+1) FEA

- Since we may now lose the best-so-far solution, we need to track it in additional variables.

procedure $(1+1)$ EA$(f : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{R})$
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  $H \leftarrow (0, 0, \cdots, 0)$;
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  $x_B \leftarrow x_c$; $y_B \leftarrow y_c$;
  while $\neg$ terminate **do**
    $x_n \leftarrow \texttt{move}(x_c)$; $y_n \leftarrow f(x_n)$;
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      $x_c \leftarrow x_n$; $y_c \leftarrow y_n$;
      if $y_c < y_B$ **then** $x_B \leftarrow x_c$; $y_B \leftarrow y_c$;
  return x_c, y_c

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- . . . which are then the return values of the $(1+1)$ FEA.

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  return x_B, y_B

FFA: What does this do?



- The rating $H[f(x)]$ of a solution x depends only on how often solutions x' with $f(x') = f(x)$ have previously been seen in the optimization process.

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- Instead, solutions with less-frequent objective values are preferred.
- Algorithms using FFA are invariant under all injective transformations of the objective function value.
- They are less likely to get stuck at local optima, which is a problem for, e.g., the $(1+1)$ EA.

Our Results

Three Core Works

snippets of [212, 214, 215]

Frequency Fitness Assignment

Thomas Weise, *Member, IEEE,* Mingxu Wan, Pu Wang, *Member, IEEE,* Ke Tang, *Senior Member, IEEE,* Alexandre Devert, and Xin Yao, *Fellow, IEEE*

***Abstract*—Metaheuristic optimization procedures such as evolutionary algorithms are usually driven by an objective function that rates the quality of a candidate solution. However, it is not clear in practice whether an objective function adequately rewards intermediate solutions on the path to the global optimum and it may exhibit deceptiveness, epistasis, neutrality, ruggedness, and a lack of causality. In this paper, we introduce the frequency fitness H, subject to minimization, which rates how often solutions with the same objective value have been discovered so far. The ideas behind this method are that good solutions are difficult to find and that if an algorithm gets stuck at a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again. We substitute a frequency fitness assignment process (FFA) for the objective function into several different optimization algorithms. We conduct a comprehensive set of experiments: the synthesis of algorithms with genetic programming (GP), the solution of MAX-SAT problems with genetic algorithms, classification with Memetic Genetic Programming, and numerical optimization with a (1+1) Evolution Strategy, to verify the utility of FFA. Given that they have no access to the original objective function at all, it is surprising that for some problems (e.g., the algorithm synthesis task) the FFA-based algorithm variants perform significantly better. However, this cannot be guaranteed for all tested problems. Thus, we also analyze scenarios where algorithms using FFA do not perform better or perform even worse than with the original objective functions.**

***Index Terms*—Combinatorial optimization, diversity, fitness assignment, frequency, genetic programming (GP), numerical optimization.**

I. Introduction

SINGLE-OBJECTIVE optimization is a process with the goal of finding [illegible] (global) solutions [illegible] from within a space $\mathbb{X}$ of possible solutions. An objective function f serves as quality measure guiding the search. Black-box metaheuristic approaches are methods that only require such an objective function and search operations to solve an optimization problem without any further insight into their structure. The most prominent family of these methods are evolutionary algorithms, which have wide applications ranging from engineering, planning and scheduling, numerical optimization, to even program synthesis.

Most metaheuristic optimization methods start with a randomly generated set of candidate solutions. New points in the search space are derived by modifying or combining promising existing solutions. Promising here means having a better objective value than the other points visited so far, maybe combined with some considerations about diversity. The rationale is that in the ideal case, solutions that have better objective values should be closer to the global optimum or, at least, may have even better solutions in their vicinity.

The principle of tending to choose areas of the solution space for sampling where points with better objective values have previously been discovered is one of the most universally applied ideas in black-box optimization. Lehman and Stanley [1] argued that increasing fitness does not always reveal the best path through the search space. Building on their work, we believe that there is at least one other fundamental principle inherent to non-trivial optimization problems that can be exploited to solve them: good solutions (and hence, good objective values) are hard to find.

If [illegible]ns[illegible]r optimization as a search [illegible] of the [illegible]nace [illegible]v[illegible]uld exp[illegible]r[illegible]requ[illegible]

Manuscript received [illegible]; revised [illegible]; accepted [illegible]. Date of publication [illegible]; date of current version [illegible]. This work was supported in part by the National Natural Science Foundation of China under Grant [illegible], in part by the Fundamental Research Funds for the Central Universities, and in part by the Natural Science Foundation of Anhui Province under Grant [illegible]. This paper was recommended by Associate Editor [illegible].

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Digital Object Identifier [illegible]

Three Core Works

snippets of [212, 214, 215]

Frequency Fitness A

Thomas Weise, *Member, IEEE,* Mingxu Wan, Pu Wang, *Me*
Alexandre Devert, and Xin Ya

***Abstract*—Metaheuristic optimization procedures such as evolutionary algorithms are usually driven by an objective function that rates the quality of a candidate solution. However, it is not clear in practice whether an objective function adequately rewards intermediate solutions on the path to the global optimum and it may exhibit deceptiveness, epistasis, neutrality, ruggedness, and a lack of causality. In this paper, we introduce the frequency fitness H, subject to minimization, which rates how often solutions with the same objective value have been discovered so far. The ideas behind this method are that good solutions are difficult to find and that if an algorithm gets stuck at a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again. We substitute a frequency fitness assignment process (FFA) for the objective function into several different optimization algorithms. We conduct a comprehensive set of experiments: the synthesis of algorithms with genetic programming (GP), the solution of MAX-SSAT problems with genetic algorithms, classification with Memetic Genetic Programming, and numerical optimization with a (1+1) Evolution Strategy, to verify the utility of FFA. Given that they have no access to the original objective function at all, it is surprising that for some problems (e.g., the algorithm synthesis task) the FFA-based algorithm variants perform significantly better. However, this cannot be guaranteed for all tested problems. Thus, we also analyze scenarios where algorithms using FFA do not perform better or perform even worse than with the original objective functions.**

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I. Introduction

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Frequency Fitness Assignment: Making Optimization Algorithms Invariant Under Bijective Transformations of the Objective Function Value

Thomas Weise, *Member, IEEE*, Zhize Wu, Xinlu Li, and Yan Chen

***Abstract*—Under frequency fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency in fitness assignment steps and is subject to minimization. FFA renders optimization processes invariant under bijective transformations of the objective function value. On TwoMax, Jump, and Trap functions of dimension s, the classical (1 + 1)-EA with standard mutation at rate 1/s can have expected runtimes exponential in s. In our experiments, a (1 + 1)-FFA, the same algorithm but using FFA, exhibits mean runtimes that seem to scale as s^2 ln s. Since Jump and Trap are bijective transformations of OneMax, it behaves identical on all three. On OneMax, LeadingOnes, and Plateau problems, it seems to be slower than the (1 + 1)-EA by a factor linear in s. The (1 + 1)-FFA performs much better than the (1 + 1)-EA on W-Model and MaxSat instances. We further verify the bijection invariance by applying the Md5 checksum computation as transformation to some of the above problems and yield the same behaviors. Finally, we show that FFA can improve the performance of a memetic algorithm for job shop scheduling.**

***Index Terms*—(1+1)-EA, evolutionary algorithm (EA), frequency fitness assignment (FFA), hyper-heuristic, job shop scheduling, objective function, optimization, problem instance, randomized algorithm, Trap function.**

which are then the basis for selection. Frequency fitness assignment (FFA) [1], [2] was developed to enable algorithms to escape from local optima. In FFA, the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency so far in fitness assignment steps and is subject to minimization. As we discuss in detail in Section II, FFA turns a static optimization problem into a dynamic one where objective values that are often encountered will receive worse and worse fitness.

In this article, we uncover a so-far unexplored property of FFA: it is invariant under any bijective transformation of the objective function values. This is the strongest invariance known to us and encompasses all order-preserving mappings. Other examples for bijective transformations include the negation, permutation, or even encryption of the objective values. According to [3], invariance extends performance observed on a single function to an entire associated invariance class, that is, it generalizes from single problems to problem classes. Thereby, it hopefully fosters the prediction

Three Core Works

snippets of [212, 214, 215]

Frequency Fitness

Thomas Weise, *Member, IEEE,* Mingxu Wan, Pu Wang, *Me*
Alexandre Devert, and Xin Ya

***Abstract*—Metaheuristic optimization procedures such as evolutionary algorithms are usually driven by an objective function that rates the quality of a candidate solution. However, it is not clear in practice whether an objective function adequately rewards intermediate solutions on the path to the global optimum and it may exhibit deceptiveness, epistasis, neutrality, ruggedness, and a lack of causality. In this paper, we introduce the frequency fitness H, subject to minimization, which rates how often solutions with the same objective value have been discovered so far. The ideas behind this method are that good solutions are difficult to find and that if an algorithm gets stuck at a local optimum, the frequency of the objective values of the surrounding solutions will increase over time, which will eventually allow it to leave that region again. We substitute a frequency fitness assignment process (FFA) for the objective function into several different optimization algorithms. We conduct a comprehensive set of experiments: the synthesis of algorithms with genetic programming (GP), the solution of MAX-SAT problems with genetic algorithms, classification with Memetic Genetic Programming, and numerical optimization with a (1+1) Evolution Strategy, to verify the utility of FFA. Given that they have no access to the original objective function at all, it is surprising that for some problems (e.g., the algorithm synthesis task) the FFA-based algorithm variants perform significantly better. However, this cannot be guaranteed for all tested problems. Thus, we also analyze scenarios where algorithms using FFA do not perform better or perform even worse than with the original objective functions.**

***Index Terms*—Combinatorial optimization, diversity, fitness assignment, frequency, genetic programming (GP), numerical optimization.**

I. Introduction

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Frequency Fitness A
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***Index Terms*—(1+1)-EA, evolutionary algorithm (EA), frequency fitness assignment (FFA), job shop scheduling (JSS), Md5, Rd.**

Frequency Fitness Assignment: Optimization Without Bias for Good Solutions Can Be Efficient

Thomas Weise , Zhize Wu, Xinlu Li, Yan Chen, and Jörg Lässig

***Abstract*—A fitness assignment process transforms the features (such as the objective value) of a candidate solution to a scalar fitness, which then is the basis for selection. Under frequency fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness corresponding to an objective value is its encounter frequency in selection steps and is subject to minimization. FFA creates algorithms that are not biased toward better solutions and are invariant under all injective transformations of the objective function value. We investigate the impact of FFA on the performance of two theory inspired, state-of-the-art evolutionary algorithms, the Greedy (2 + 1) GA and the self-adjusting (1 + (λ, λ)) GA. FFA improves their performance significantly on some problems that are hard for them. In our experiments, one FFA-based algorithm exhibited mean runtimes that appear to be polynomial on the theory-based benchmark problems in our study, including traps, jumps, and plateaus. We propose two hybrid approaches that use both direct and FFA-based optimization and find that they perform well. All FFA-based algorithms also perform better on satisfiability problems than any of the pure algorithm variants.**

***Index Terms*—Evolutionary algorithm (EA), FFA, frequency fitness assignment (FFA), Ising problems, jump problems, linear harmonic functions, MaxSat problem, *N*-queens problem, OneMax, Plateau problems, satisfiability, Trap function, TwoMax, *W*-model benchmark.**

fitness assignment (FFA), the fitness of a candidate solution is the absolute encounter frequency of its objective value so far during the optimization process [1]. Being subject to minimization, FFA drives the search away from already-discovered objective values and toward solutions with new qualities.

FFA breaks with one of the most fundamental concepts of heuristic optimization: FFA-based algorithms are not biased toward better solutions [2], i.e., they do not prefer better solutions over worse ones. They also are invariant under all injective transformations of the objective function value, which is the strongest invariance property of any nontrivial single-objective optimization algorithm [3].[1] Only random sampling, random walks, and exhaustive enumeration have similar properties and neither of them is considered to be an efficient optimization method.

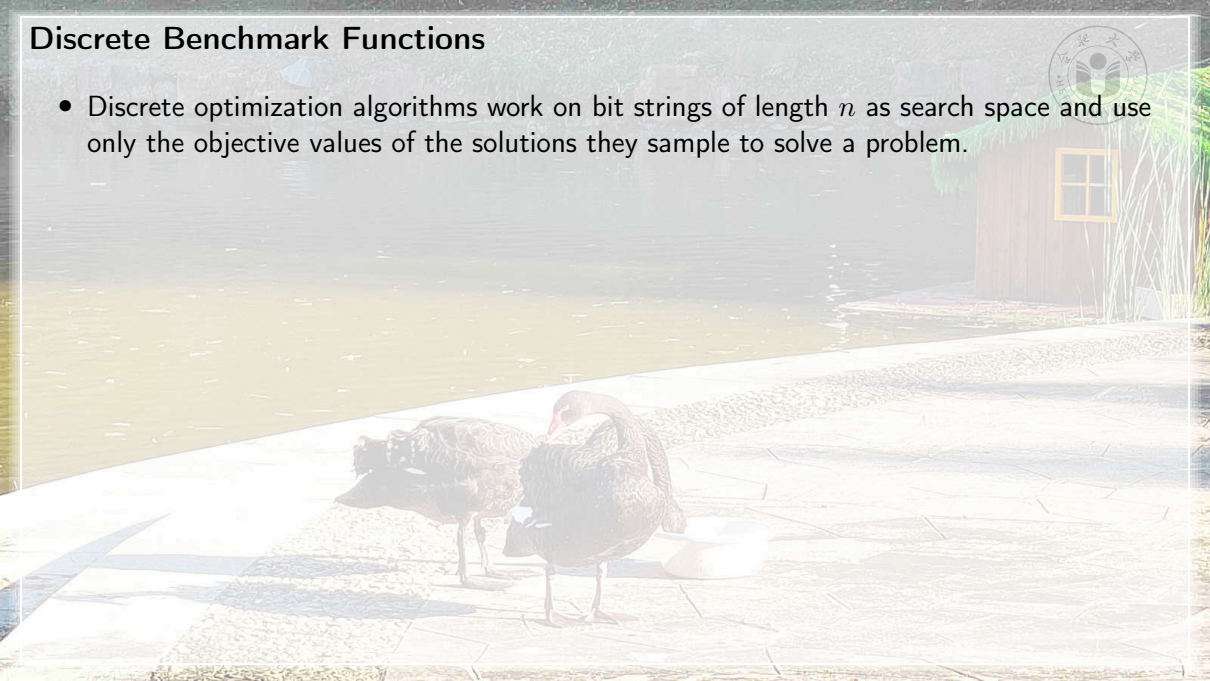
One would expect that this comes at a significant performance penalty. Yet, FFA performed well in Genetic Programming tasks with their often rugged, deceptive, and highly epistatic landscapes [1], [4] and on a benchmark problem simulating such landscapes [5]. While the (1 + 1) EA has exponential expected runtime on problems, such as Jump, TwoMax, and Trap, the (1 + 1) FEA, the same algorithm using FFA, exhibits mean runtimes that appear

I. Introduction

FITNESS ... many ... [3]

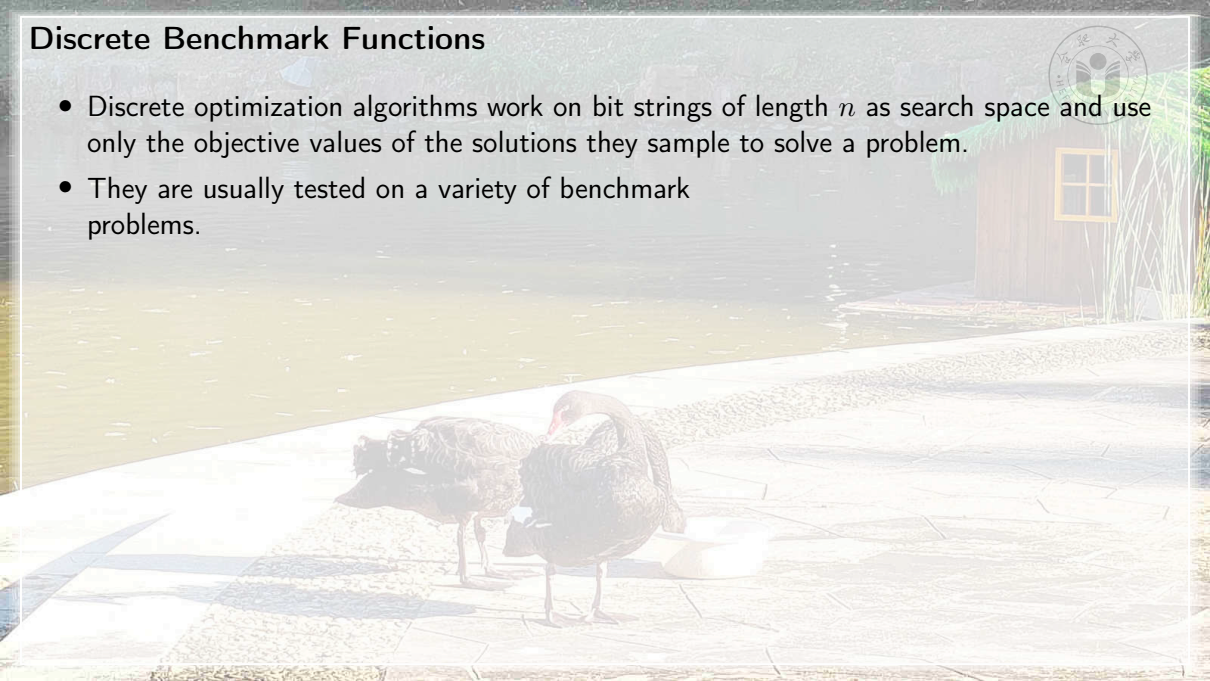
Discrete Benchmark Functions

- Discrete optimization algorithms work on bit strings of length n as search space and use only the objective values of the solutions they sample to solve a problem.



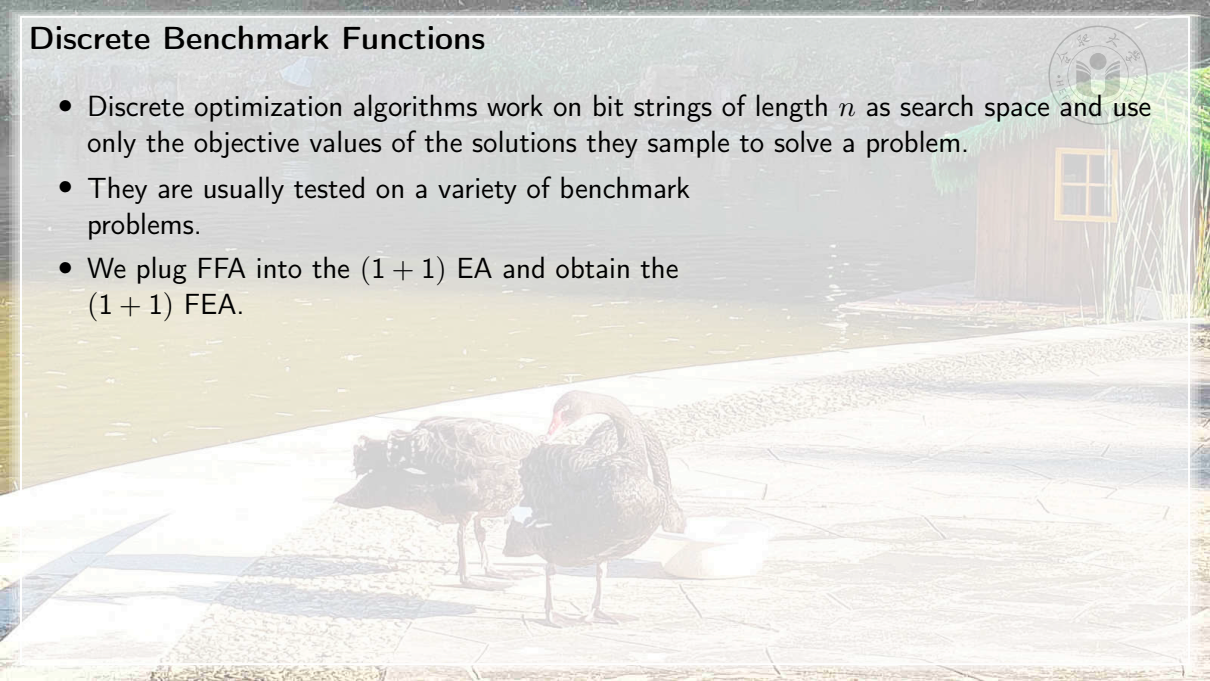
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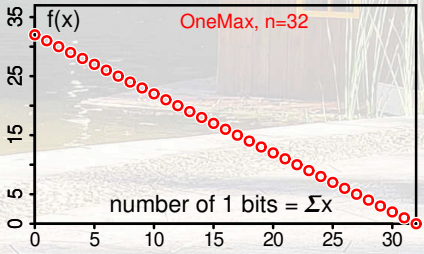
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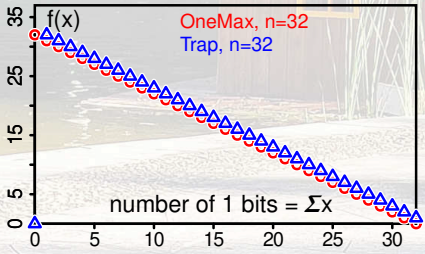
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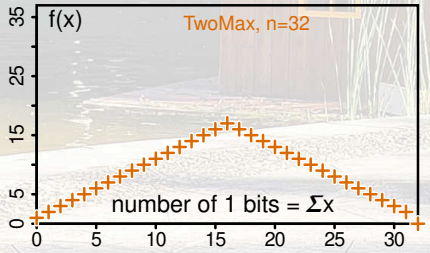
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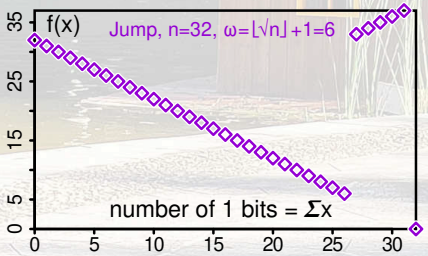


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- The $(1+1)$ FEA solves all three problems in polynomial time as well as the Jump problem, where the $(1+1)$ EA also needs exponential runtime!

Maximum Satisfiability Problem



- FFA on the Maximum Satisfiability (MaxSAT) Problem, one of the most famous discrete optimization problems [212, 214, 215].

Maximum Satisfiability Problem

- FFA on the Maximum Satisfiability (MaxSAT) Problem, one of the most famous discrete optimization problems [212, 214, 215].

> From Table I, we can see that **the highest number of failed runs at scale $s = 250$ of *any* algorithm using FFA is lower than the lowest number of failed runs of *any* pure algorithm at $s = 50$.** From Table II, we find that no FFA-based algorithm has a higher ERT at scale $s = 250$ than its pure variant on $s = 50$. On the scales $s \leq 75$, the FFA-based algorithms have a mean runtime which is between three and four orders of magnitude smaller that the ERT of the pure algorithms.

- Snippet of page 10 of [215] (copyright IEEE).
- Several different EAs with and without FFA

Traveling Salesperson Problem

- FFA on the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP): [131–133].

Traveling Salesperson Problem

- FFA on the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP): [131–133].
- Snippet of page 12 of [131] (copyright Springer).
- $(1+1)$ EA, $(1+1)$ FEA, Simulated Annealing (SA) w/o FFA, hybrids

In this work, we explored both the EA and SA on 56 symmetric instances from the benchmark set TSPLib (Reinelt 1991, 1995). The EA is unsuitable for this problem, but SA can find the optimum on many small and mid-sized instances. We then plug FFA into both algorithms and obtain the FEA and the FSA, respectively, which both exhibit very similar performance. **The FEA solves 27 of the instances in all of its runs, which SA can only achieve for 19 instances.** Plugging FFA into either the EA or SA thus substantially improved the number of runs in which the algorithms can find the optimum, however, both FFA-based variants suffer when the number of unique objective values is high.

• • •

Both types of **hybridization** methods significantly improve the average result quality compared to both the objective-guided and FFA-based FEA variants. **The SAFEA$_A$ discovers the optimal solutions in more runs than any other algorithm setup in our study.** It also finds the optimum most often in most instances and delivers the best approximation quality on most instances, compared to the other algorithms.

Quadratic Assignment Problem



- FFA on the Quadratic Assignment Problem (QAP): [39, 195].

Quadratic Assignment Problem

- FFA on the Quadratic Assignment Problem (QAP): [39, 195].
- Snippet of page 7 of [39] (copyright SciTePress).
- RLS w/o FFA

We find that the **FFA-based** randomized local search **FRLS does not just find better solutions than the objective-guided RLS algorithm on the vast majority of the QAPLIB instances**, it also keeps improving its current best solution for the complete computational budget of 10^8 FEs that we assigned to the runs. With this budget, **it can discover the optimal solutions of over 58% of the QAPLIB instances**. Had we assigned a larger budget – (Liang et al., 2022; Liang et al., 2024; Weise et al., 2021b; Weise et al., 2023) use 10^{10} FEs – we would likely have seen even more instances solved.

We furthermore confirm the remarkable ability of FFA to discover very diverse solutions (at least from the perspective of the objective function). It is known that on the QAP, many solutions tend to have the same objective values (Tayarani-N. and Prügel-Bennett, 2015). Yet, on some of the instances, more than half of the objective values discovered by FRLS were unique.

Job Shop Scheduling Problem



- FFA on the Job Shop Scheduling Problem (JSSP) Problem: [49, 209, 214].

Job Shop Scheduling Problem

- FFA on the Job Shop Scheduling Problem (JSSP) Problem: [49, 209, 214].

> The **end result quality delivered by (1+1)-FEA is better in average on the abz*, ft*, la*, orb*, and yn4* instance sets, both in terms of *best* and *mean*.** On swv*, the average for *mean* is better for (1+1)-FEA, while (1+1)-EA has a slight lead in *best*. The (1+1)-EA performs better on the dmu* and ta* instances. Since these two sets are larger (holding 160 out of the 242 instances), the (1+1)-EA comes out ahead in the overall averages, but with no more than a 1.5% advantage.

- Snippet of page 10 of [209] (copyright ACM).

Algorithm Synthesis and Genetic Programming



- FFA for algorithm synthesis and Genetic Programming (GP): [211, 212].

Algorithm Synthesis and Genetic Programming

- FFA for algorithm synthesis and Genetic Programming (GP): [211, 212].

> Fourth, we were able to confirm with great significance that **FFA** has a tremendous positive impact on the performance of GP, as it **can increase the success rate by 40%.**

- Snippet of page 7 of [211] (copyright IEEE).

Future Works



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- Apply FFA to other discrete and combinatorial problems.

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  1. Where can FFA improve the solution quality?

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- Plug FFA into more optimization algorithms.

Future Works

- Apply FFA to other discrete and combinatorial problems:
  1. Where can FFA improve the solution quality?
  2. Where can it not do that?
  3. Why?
- Plug FFA into more optimization algorithms.
- Combine "traditional" and FFA-based optimization, i.e., create hybrid algorithms, to reap the best of both worlds.

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Summary

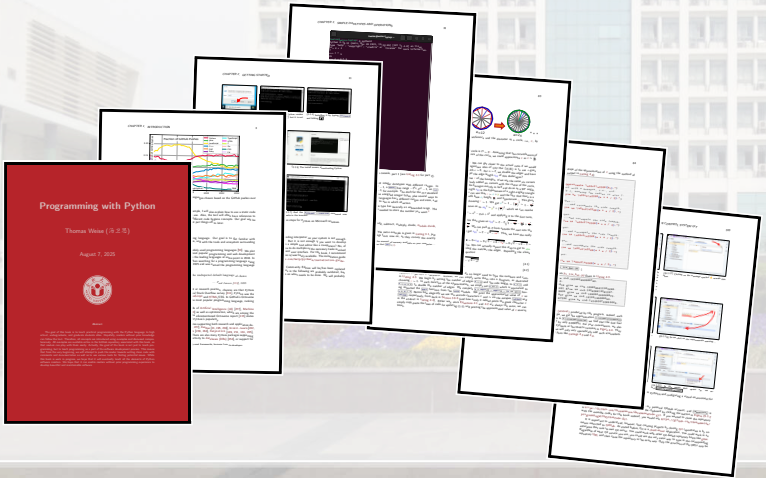


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  2. on the Traveling Tournament Problem (TTP), we also got surprisingly good results with RLS[220] and SA.

Advertisement

Programming with Python

We have a freely available course book on *Programming with Python* at `https://thomasweise.github.io/programmingWithPython`, with focus on practical software development using the Python ecosystem of tools[207].



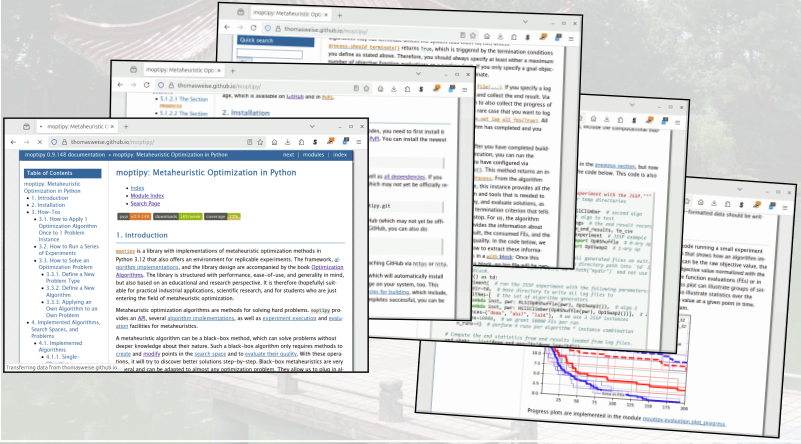
Databases

We have a freely available course book on *Databases* at `https://thomasweise.github.io/databases`, with actual practical examples using a real database management system (DBMS)[203].



Metaheuristic Optimization in Python: moptipy

We offer moptipy[213], a mature open source Python package for metaheuristic optimization, which implements several algorithms, can run self-documenting experiments in parallel and in a distributed fashion, and offers statistical evaluation tools.



谢谢您们！

Thank you!

Vielen Dank!



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Glossary I

$(1+1)$ EA The $(1+1)$ EA is a local search algorithm that retains the best solution x_c discovered so far during the search [34,65]. In each step, it applies a unary search operator to this best-so-far solution x_c and derives a new solution x_n. If the new solution x_n is *better or equally good* when compared with x_c, i.e., not worse, then it replaces it, i.e., is stored as the new x_c. If the search space are bit strings of length n, then the $(1+1)$ EA uses a unary search operator that flips each bit independently with probability m/n, where usually $m = 1$. This operator is the main difference to randomized local search (RLS). The $(1+1)$ EA is a special case of the $(\mu+\lambda)$ evolutionary algorithm ($(\mu+\lambda)$ EA) where $\mu = \lambda = 1$.

$(1+1)$ FEA The $(1+1)$ EA with FFA plugged in [214,215,224]. On the discrete bit-string domains, this algorithm has a very specific structure: Its unary search operator flips each bit with probability $1/n$, where n is the dimension of the search space, distinguishing it from the unary operator in FRLS which flips exactly one bit. On other domains, such as permutations, the term is used synonymously with FRLS.

$(\mu+\lambda)$ EA The $(\mu+\lambda)$ EA is an evolutionary algorithm (EA) where, in each generation, λ offspring solutions are generated from the current population of μ parent solutions. The offspring and parent populations are merged, yielding $\mu+\lambda$ solutions, from which then the best μ solutions are ratained to form the parent population of the next generation. If the search space is the bit strings of length n, then this algorithm usually applies a mutation operator flipping each bit independently with probability $1/n$.

BinInt The *Binary Integer Problem* is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [194,224]. It is very similar to OneMax: It tries to maximize the number of 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n. Different from OneMax, where each bit has the same weight in the objective function, the bits of BinInt have a exponentially increasing weight: The bit string is treated as a binary-encoded integer whose value should be maximized. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = 2^n - 1 - \sum_{i=1}^{n} 2^{i-1} \cdot x_i$. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. It is fully separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately.

LinHarm The Linear Harmonic Function is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [59,65,224]. It is very similar to OneMax: It tries to maximize the number of 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n. Different from OneMax, where each bit has the same weight in the objective function, the bits of LinHarm have a linear increasing weight. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = \frac{1}{2}n(n+1) - \sum_{i=1}^{n} i \cdot x_i$. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. It is fully separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately. The $(1+1)$ EA can solve this problem with an expected runtime in $\Theta(n \ln n)$ [59,65].

Glossary II

2BP In the two-dimensional Bin Packing Problem (BP), the goal is to pack rectangles into rectangular bins without overlap and such that their edges are parallel to the edges of the bins [105,136,138]. The 2BP is strongly $\mathcal{NP}$-hard [138]. The variants of this problem include the 2BP|O|F, 2BP|R|F, 2BP|O|G, and 2BP|R|G [137,138]. Different objective function for the 2BP|O|F and 2BP|R|F are presented in [226]. 2BPs have many practical applications, including cutting (wood, glas) [138], packing (transportation, warehouse) [138], and newspaper page layout [187].

2BP|O|F In the oriented 2BP with free cuts, the rectangles to pack have fixed orientations, i.e., cannot be rotated, but can otherwise be arranged freely [137,138,147,227]. Permutation-based search spaces can be used for this problem by using the Improved Bottom Left (IBL) encoding. The SOTA for this problem comprises [21,26,42,89,164,227].

2BP|O|G In the oriented 2BP with guillotine cuts, the rectangles to pack have fixed orientations, i.e., cannot be rotated, and must be arranged such that they can be extracted by edge-to-edge cuts [137,138].

2BP|R|F In this variant of the 2BP with free cuts, the rectangles to pack can be rotated by 90° if need be and can freely be arranged [18,137,138,226,227]. Besides packing and cutting, this problem also occurs in scheduling and build formation in additive manufacturing [130,168]. The almost-squares-in-almost-squares (Asqas) problem [198] is also a 2BP|R|F. Search spaces based on signed permutations can be used for this problem by using the IBL encoding. The SOTA for this problem comprises [21,42,89,226,227].

2BP|R|G In this variant of the 2BP with guillotine cuts, the rectangles to pack can be rotated by 90° if need be, but must be arranged such that they can be extracted by edge-to-edge cuts [137,138].

ACO *Ant Colony Optimization* is a nature-inspired optimization method for combinatorial problems where solutions are generated by "ants" that move from node to node in a graph choosing edges based on (1) the simulated pheromone on the edges and (2) a per-edge heuristic value [61–63]. If an ant produced a good solution, "pheromone" is distributed over the edges it visited, making it more likely to be re-visited by other ants.

AI Artificial Intelligence, see, e.g., [178]

Glossary III



Asqas An "almost-square" be a rectangle with size $i \times (i+1)$ with $i \in \mathbb{N}_1$. The *almost-squares-in-almost-squares* problem [198] is a special case of the 2BP|R|F. Here, almost-square rectangles of sizes 1×2, 2×3, $\ldots$, $n \times (n+1)$ must be placed into an almost-square bin without waste. This requires that there exists a natural number $p \in \mathbb{N}_1$ such that $p(p+1) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} i(i+1)$ [198]. There are exacty five Asqas instances [198], namely with bin sizes 1×2 for $n = 1$, $p = 1$, 5×4 for $n = 3$, $p = 4$, 15×16 for $n = 8$, $p = 15$, 55×56 for $n = 20$, $p = 55$, and 119×120 for $n = 34$, $p = 119$.

ATSP The general case for TSPs are *asymmetric Traveling Salesperson Problems*, where the $n \times n$ distance matrix A does not need to be symmetric. In other words, it is possible that $\exists a, b \in 1..n$ with $A[a, b] \neq A[b, a]$. Notice that while such index tuple *may* exist, this is not always or necessarily the case. In this case, one may consider the STSP as a special case of the ATSP, while ATSPs may be considered as synonymous to TSPs.

BP The *Bin Packing Problem* [68,180] is one of the classical problems from Operations Research (OR). The goal is to pack a set of objects into containers, using as few containers as possible. Different flavors of BPs can be distinguished, e.g., by the number of dimensions [52,136] that the objects and containers have (see, e.g., the 2BP), and/or whether the objects can be rotated [227], as well as other constraints and limitations. Both the one- and two-dimensional BP are strongly $\mathcal{NP}$-hard [138].

BRKGA The *Biased Random Key Genetic Algorithm* is a EA with a continuous search space $\mathbb{X} \subset [0, 1]^n$ and a decoding function γ translating this space to something else and biased, uniform, and elitist mating strategies [91,141].The *bias* comes from the fact that one of the parents used for the binary operation is biased to be of higher fitness than the other parent [91]. Often, γ is the Random Keys encoding [12,13] procedure translating $\mathbb{X}$ to permutations of the first n natural numbers [90]. Sometimes, it is actually a MA further refining the translation result with a local search (LS) [90]. Sometimes the permutations are then further translated to more complex data structures, such as Gantt charts for the JSSP [90], or packing plans for 2BP 3D packing [89].

C is a programming language, which is very successful in system programming situations [56,172,206].

Concorde is an exact solver for the TSP[4,44,45], which could even solve the largest instance of TSPLib (with 85 900 cities) to optimality.

DB A *database* is an organized collection of structured information or data, typically stored electronically in a computer system. Databases are discussed in our book *Databases* [203].

Glossary IV

DBMS A *database management system* is the software layer located between the user or application and the database (DB). The DBMS allows the user/application to create, read, write, update, delete, and otherwise manipulate the data in the DB [222].

EA An *evolutionary algorithm* is a metaheuristic optimization method that maintains a population of candidate solutions, which undergo selection (where better solutions are chosen with higher probability) and reproduction (where mutation and recombination create a new candidate solution from one or two existing ones, repectively) [7,204].

FFA *Frequency Fitness Assignment* (中文: 频率适应度分配) is a algorithm plugin for optimization methods applied to discrete or combinatorial problems with not-too-many different possible objective values [212,214,215]. It replaces the objective values in all comparisons with their absolute encounter frequency so far during the search. FFA has successfully been applied to the MaxSAT [214,215], the TSP [131,132], and the QAP [39,195], amongst others. Its properties have been intensely researched on discrete benchmark functions such as OneMax, LeadingOnes, Trap, TwoMax, Jump, and Plateau [214,215,224]. The most common realizations of FFA so far are the $(1+1)$ FEA and FRLS.

FSSP The *Flow Shop Scheduling Problem* is a variant of a JSSP where all products go through the same sequence of machines [93,114].

Gantt chart Gantt charts are two-dimensional diagrams illustrating the steps of a process [116,218]. Their horizontal axis represents the time, the vertical axis represents work packages, machines, or workers. In the diagram area, bars located at certain vertical locations indicate that the work package, machine, or worker is processed or works at the time range covered by the bar as projected to the horizontal axis.

GP *Genetic Programming* [121,169,204,210] is the application of metaheuristic optimization, usually in form of an EAs, to a search space comprised of tree data structures. These tree data structures often represent programs or mathematical expressions.

GRASP A *Greedy Randomized Adaptive Search Procedure* is a metaheuristic where each cycle consists of two main components [72,74,75]: First, a starting point is generated using a heuristic method (as opposed to being randomly sampled). Then, a LS is applied to refine the solution. Then, another cycle starts and proceeds in the same way. The overall best solution is retained as result. Many examples of applications of GRASPs are listed in [75]. GRASP in combination with VND has been applied to the 2BP|O|F in [164].

Glossary V

IBL The *improved bottom left* heuristic is a one-shot algorithm constructing a solution for 2BP [135]. For the 2BP|O|F problem variant, the input of the IBL algorithm is a permutation of the first n natural numbers, each number identifying one rectangle to be packed. For the 2BP|R|F problem flavor, the permutation elements are signed, where a negative sign indicates a rotation by 90° [135]. In [226,227] it is adapted to a multi-bin situation as follows: The algorithm iterates over the (potentially signed) permutation x and places the rectangles into the packing plan in the prescribed order. It first places the rectangle outside on top of the current bin b, with its bottom-right corner onto the top-right corner of the current bin b. It then moves the rectangle downwards and leftwards as far as possible, prioritizing the downward movement whenever possible. If the rectangle cannot be moved any further, it checks if it is completely contained in the bin b. If yes, it can remain there. Otherwise, a new bin is opened ($b \leftarrow b + 1$) and the rectangle is placed at its bottom-left corner. Once a new bin is opened, this bin is used for all further insertions. IBL is suitable as a decoding function γ inside an EA [135]. Historically, it improves upon the BL algorithm [109]: That algorithm cannot represent all possible optimal packings using a permutation, but the IBL can [135].

ILS An *iterated local search* is a variant of the LS which applies cycles of local search and perturbation [188]. First, an initial solution is generated and refined by the local search. Then the cycle begins: A perturbation, i.e., a large search move that likely destroys a good part of the solution, is applied. The resulting new solution is refined by local search. Then, an acceptance criterion decides whether we should use this or the previous solution to continue in the next cycle. ILS has successfully been applied to the QAP.

Ising Model The Ising models are benchmark problems for bit-string based black-box search [59,76,77,224]. Here, a neighborhood is defined around each bit. The bit needs to have the same value as all bits in the neighborhood structure T. Thus, we try to achieve that all bits have the same value. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem family can be defined as $f(x, T) = \sum_{(i,j)\in T} |x_i - x_j|$, where T contains the index pairs of neighboring bits and is defined differently for the Ising model instances Ising 1D and Ising 2D. The problems are highly epistatic, as all variables interact with some other variables.

Ising 1D The 1D is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [59,77,224]. The bits are arranged in a one-dimensional ring and we try to minimize the number of bits that have different values than their neighbors. Hence, the neighborhood structure T is defined as $T_{\mathbf{1D}} = \{(i+1, (i+1 \bmod n)+1) \mid i \in [0..n-1]\}$. The problems are highly epistatic, as all variables interact with some other variables. The $(1+1)$ EA has an expected runtime in $\mathcal{O}(n^3)$ on 1-Dimensional Ising Model (Ising 1D) [77].

Glossary VI

Ising 2D The 2D is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [59,76,224]. The bits are arranged in a two-dimensional torus and we try to minimize the number of bits that have different values than their neighbors. Hence, the neighborhood structure $T = T_{2D}$ is defined as the set of all $\{(\alpha + \beta N, \gamma + \delta N)\}$ pairs with $\alpha, \beta, \gamma, \delta \in 0..N-1$ and either $()\gamma = (\alpha + 1) \bmod N$ and $\delta = \beta$) or ($\gamma = \alpha$ and $\delta = (\beta + 1) \bmod N$) with $n = N^2$. The problems are highly epistatic, as all variables interact with some other variables. On a similar class of problems, the $(1 + 1)$ EA has an exponential expected runtime [76].

Java is another very successful programming language, with roots in the C family of languages [25,142].

JSSP The *Job Shop Scheduling Problem* [24,41,93,126] is one of the most prominent and well-studied scheduling tasks. In a JSSP instance, there are m machines and k jobs [189]. Each job must be processed once by each machine in a job-specific sequence and has a job-specific processing time on each machine. The goal is to find an assignment of jobs to machines that results in an overall shortest makespan, i.e., the schedule (Gantt chart) which can complete all the jobs in the shortest time. The JSSP is $\mathcal{NP}$-complete [37,125,126]. The 8 most common sets of JSSP benchmark instances are *abz* [1], *dmu* [53], *ft* [78], *la* [128], *orb* [5], *swv* [186], *ta* [189], and *yn* [221].Their data can be found (sometimes partially) in several repositories, such as the OR-Library [14,15], [182], and [205], the latter of which also contains many results from existing works. Encodings based on permutations with repetition are proposed in [22,23,84,181] and used in [214]. The SOTA of the JSSP includes [90,99,163,165,183,202,225].

Jump The Jump problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [65,81,224]. Like the OneMax, it tries to maximize the number of 1 bits in a bit string of chosen length n. However, the solutions representing the last ω bits around the optimum to flip are deceptive, meaning that they are actually worse and getting worse than surrounding solutions. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is $n - \|x\|_1$ if $\|x\|_1 = n$ or $\|x\|_1 \leq n - \omega$ hold, and $\omega + \|x\|_1$ otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i$. This means that, the larger ω, the larger the deceptive basin around the optimum that an algorithm needs to cross. An $(1 + 1)$ EA will converge to the resulting local optimum and thus have an expected runtime of $\Theta(n^\omega + n \ln n)$ [65].In experiments, the $(1 + 1)$ FEA achieves polynomial runtime on Jump, seemingly in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ [214,215,224].

Glossary VII



LABS *Low-Autocorrelation Binary Sequences* are bit strings of length n whose autocorrelation is as low as possible [27–29,54,55,82,148,150,156,161,171]. This means that sub-sequences of any length $1 \leq k < n$ should ideally never repeat. The objective function $f : \{0,1\}^n \mapsto \mathbb{N}_0$ represents the energy of a bit string x and is subject to minimization. We can define it as $f(x) = \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \left(\sum_{i=0}^{n-1-k} s_i \cdot s_{i+k}\right)^2$ with $s_j = 2x_j - 1$. Such sequences are needed for communication engineering [28,29,156], cryptography[54,156], as well as modulation pulses in radar and sonar ranging[161]. The LABS is $\mathcal{NP}$-hard [197]. The SOTA on LABS contains [27,29,54,55,156].

LeadingOnes The LeadingOnes problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [177,217,224]. It tries to maximize the number of *leading* 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = n - \sum_{i=1}^{n} \prod_{j=1}^{i} x_j$. Different from OneMax, the contribution to the objective value of the bit at index i thus depends on the state of all the bits *before* this index. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. Different from OneMax, it is not separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately. The expected runtime of $(1+1)$ EA on LeadingOnes is in $\Theta(n^2)$ [65]. The average runtime $(1+1)$ FEA on LeadingOnes seems to be slower by factor proportional to n, i.e., seems to be in $\mathcal{O}(n^3)$ [214].

LK The *Lin-Kernighan* (LK) algorithm [134] is a SLS method for the TSP. The LK algorithm performs iterative k-opt moves, i.e., in each step, it constructs the two sets X and Y of k edges such that removing the edges in X from the current tour T and then adding the edges from Y to T results in a better tour.The LK algorithm is one of the most classical approaches to the TSP.

LKH The *Lin-Kernighan-Helsgaun* algorithm [45,97,98] is a SLS method for the TSP based on the Lin-Kernighan (LK) algorithm [134]. LKH-1 was proposed in [98] and LKH-2 in [97]. It holds the record in the *World TSP* [46] as of 2025.

LS A *local search* is an algorithm where a single "current" candidate solution is maintained and new solutions are selected from its neighborhood in each step. Most LSes are randomized, i.e., stochastic local search (SLS).

MA A *Memetic Algorithm* is an EA where each new solution is refined by a LS before it enters the population [204]. As LS, we can use, e.g., RLS, but TS [40,79] is maybe a better choise. Some SOTA algorithms in some domains may be classified as MAs, e.g., Lin-Kernighan Helsgaun (LKH) basically uses a population that is refined via a local search. MAs also worked well on the JSSP [40,99] and the TSP [79].

Glossary VIII



MaxSAT
: The goal of satisfiability problems is to find an assignment for n Boolean variables that make a given Boolean formula $F : \{0,1\}^n \mapsto \{0,1\}$ become true. In the *Maximum Satisfiability* problem (MaxSAT) [100], F is given in conjunctive normal form, i.e., the variables appear either directly or negated in m "or" clauses, which are all combined into one "and." The objective function $f(x)$, subject to minimization, computes the number of clauses which are false under the variable setting x. If $f(x) = 0$, then all clauses of F are true, which solves the problem. The MaxSAT problem is $\mathcal{NP}$-complete [43] and exhibits low epistasis but deceptiveness [174], making it hard for local searches. Typical benchmark instances can be found in SATLIB, which contains smaller-scale instances, and the up-to-date MaxSAT Evaluation (MSE), providing SOTA benchmarks, algorithms, and results.

metaheuristic
: A *metaheuristic* is an optimization algorithm which performs a cycle of trial and error during which candidate solutions are sampled from the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$ and evaluated using an objective function $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ [87,204]. The results of the objective function are used to decide which solution is promising. The neighborhoods around promising solutions *or* similarly-structured solutions are then sampled in the next cycle. Prominent metaheuristics are SLSes, SA, TS, and EAs.

moptipy
: is the *Metaheuristic Optimization in Python* library [213]. It has been used in several different research works, including [39,131–133,195,220,226,227]. Algorithms implemented by moptipy include EAs, $(1+1)$ EA, RLS, SA, and the $(1+1)$ FEA, amongst others. Learn more at https://thomasweise.github.io/moptipy and https://thomasweise.github.io/moptipyapps.

MSE
: The *MaxSAT Evaluation* is a regularly updated set of benchmark instances for the MaxSAT [106]. It also includes solver software and benchmark results [200].

N-Queens
: The N-Queens Problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [59,224]. The goal is to arrange N queens on an $N \times N$ chessboard so that none can attack the other. The search space has thus dimension $n = N^2$, with each bit standing for a field and encoding whether or not a queen is placed there. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is $N - \left(\sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i\right) - N \sum_{\xi} \max\left\{0, Q_\xi(x) - 1\right\}$ where $Q_\xi(x)$ is the number of queens in the horizontal, vertical, or diagonale ξ. The problem is quite epistatic.

Glossary IX



OneMax OneMax is the simplest possible benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [66,157,224]. The goal is to maximize the number of 1 bits in the bit string of a chosen dimension n. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant of this problem can be defined as $f(x) = n - \sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i$. The problem is unimodal, i.e., has only a single global optimum and no local optimum. It is fully separable, i.e., we can optimize each variable separately. The expected runtime of $(1+1)$ EA on OneMax is in $\Theta(n \ln n)$ [57,157]. The average runtime $(1+1)$ FEA on OneMax seems to be slower by factor proportional to n, i.e., seems to be in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ [214].

OR Operations Research (or Operational Research) is the application of sciences such as mathematics and computer science to the management and organization of systems, organizations, enterprises, factories, or projects. It encompasses the development and application of problem-solving methods and techniques (such as mathematical optimization, simulation, queueing theory and other stochastic models) with the goal to improve decision-making and efficiency [50].

OR-Library is a library of benchmark instances for various OR problems [14,15] located at https://people.brunel.ac.uk/~mastjjb/jeb/info.html. It contains instances of the JSSP, 1D- and 2D-Packing, Knapsack, periodic TSPs, amongst others.

Plateau The Plateau problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [3,224]. It is structured exactly like Jump, but instead of being deceptive, the last ω bits to flip around the optimum are neutral. The objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is $n - \|x\|_1$ if $\|x\|_1 = n$ or $\|x\|_1 \leq n - \omega$ hold, and ω otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i$. This means that, the larger ω, the larger the neutral plane around the optimum that an algorithm needs to cross. An $(1+1)$ EA has an expected runtime of $\Theta(n^\omega)$ on plateaus [3]. The average runtime of the $(1+1)$ FEA on Plateaus is slower by a factor seemingly proportional in n.

PostgreSQL An open source object-relational DBMS [73,160,170,193]. See https://postgresql.org for more information.

Python The Python programming language [103,129,144,207], i.e., what you will learn about in our book [207]. Learn more at https://python.org.

Glossary X

QAP The *Quadratic Assignment Problem* is an optimization problem where the goal is to assign a set of n facilities to a set of n locations [31,39,120,139]. Such an assignment can be represented as a permutation x of the first n natural numbers, where x_i specifies the location where facility i should be placed. For each QAP instance, a distance matrix A is given, where $A[a, b]$ specifies the distance from location a to location b, as well as a flow matrix B, where $B[i, j]$ is the amount of material flowing (e.g., daily) from facility i to facility j. The objective function $f(x)$ then rates a permutation x as $f(x) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \sum_{j=1}^{n} A[x_i, x_j] * B[i, j]$. The QAP is $\mathcal{NP}$-complete [64,179] and even among this problem class, is considered as particularly hard for metaheuristics [16,31,139,188]. The QAP has applications such as building layout [48,70,122], keyboard layout [33], circuit design [71], wiring [185], and scheduling [184]. Typical benchmark instances can be found in QAPLIB. SOTA algorithms for the QAP include [16,79,149,154,191,192].

QAPLIB is a library of 136 benchmark instances for the Quadratic Assignment Problem (QAP) [30,32], 28 of which have not yet been solved to optimality [2] (at least by 2023).

Random Keys encoding is a decoding procedure $\gamma : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{Y}$ that maps a continuous search space $\mathbb{X} \subset [0, 1]^n$ which is a subset of the n-dimensional real numbers to the space $\mathbb{Y}$ of permutations of the first n natural numbers [12,13]. For example, on $n = 5$, the vector $x = (0.49, 0.91, 0.33, 0.75, 0.51)$ is translated to the permutation $y = (3, 1, 5, 4, 2)$, because $x_{\mathbf{3}} = 0.33$ has the smallest value, putting 3 at the beginning, $x_{\mathbf{1}} = 0.49$ the second-smallest, placing 1 second, ..., and $x_{\mathbf{2}} = 0.91$ being the largest value meaning that the last number in y will be 2 [13]. The advantage of the encoding is that we can search in $\mathbb{X}$ applying arbitrary mathematical operators, crossover, and mutation procedures, but will always get correct permutations. The disadvantage is that $|\mathbb{X}| \gg |\mathbb{Y}|$ and that there actually is no meaning underpinning moves in $\mathbb{X}$ in relation to their projected result in $\mathbb{Y}$.

RLS Randomized local search retains the best solution x_c discovered so far during the search and, in each step, it applies a unary search operator to this best-so-far solution x_c and derives a new solution x_n. If the new solution x_n is *better or equally good* when compared with x_c, i.e., not worse, then it replaces it, i.e., is stored as the new x_c. If the search space are bit strings of length n, then RLS uses a unary search operator that flips exactly one bit. This operator is the main difference to $(1 + 1)$ EA.

FRLS The RLS with FFA plugged in [224]. On the discrete bit-string domains, this algorithm has a very specific structure: Its unary search operator flips exactly one bit, distinguishing it from the unary operator in the $(1 + 1)$ FEA, which flips each bit with probability $1/n$. On other domains, such as permutations, we use the term synonymously with $(1 + 1)$ FEA.

Glossary XI

RTS *Reactive Tabu Search* is a variant of TS where the length of the tabu list is adapted to the problem and to the current evolution of the search, and an escape strategy for diversifying the search is used when that is not sufficient [8–11]. It has successfully been applied to a wide range of problems, from the QAP [9,10], to Knapsack problems [8,10], the N-K landscape [8] to the training of neural networks [11].

SA *Simulated Annealing* is a SLS that sometimes accepts a worse solution [35,108,115,167,204]. The probability to do so decreases over time and with the difference in objective values, i.e.,is the lower the worse the new solution is. SA performed well on a variety of problems, including the QAP [152,196] and the JSSP [163].

SATLIB is a library of benchmark instances for the Maximum Satisfiability (MaxSAT) available at https://www.cs.ubc.ca/~hoos/SATLIB/index-ubc.html [101,102].

SLS *Stochastic local search* is a local search (LS), one of the simplest metaheuristic search paradigms [100]: A single "current" candidate solution is maintained and new solutions are *stochastically* sampled from its neighborhood, i.e., in a way that involves random numbers. If these solutions are deemed interesting based on their objective value, they replace the "current". The cycle continues. Basic examples are RLS and $(1+1)$ EA. More complex examples that add mechanisms to escape local optima on top of the SLS paradigm are TS and SA.

SOTA State-of-the-Art, i.e., the best-performing methods for a field or problem type

STSP A *symmetric Traveling Salesperson Problem* is a special case of the TSP, where the $n \times n$ distance matrix A is symmetric, i.e., $A[a,b] = A[b,a] \forall a,b \in 1..n$.

Trap The Trap problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [65,158,224]. It is structured exactly like OneMax, however the worst and the best solution are swapped. This makes the problem highly deceptive, as following the "gradient" in the search space leads the search away from the global optimum. For bit strings of length n, the objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is 0 if $\|x\|_1 = 0$ and $n - \|x\|_1 + 1$ otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i$. An $(1+1)$ EA will converge to the resulting local optimum and thus have an expected runtime of $\Theta(n^n)$ [65]. In experiments, the $(1+1)$ FEA achieves polynomial runtime on Trap, seemingly in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ [214,215,224].

Glossary XII

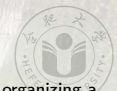


TS *Tabu Search* is one of the most successful SLSes [85,86,88,110]. In order to avoid returning to previous solutions, it declares certain solutions or search moves as "tabu." For example, if a bit in a discrete problem has been flipped by the search operator, it may be forbidden to flip the bit again for some time, thus preventing the algorithm from getting trapped in a cycle. This rule may be overridden if a new best-so-far solution is discovered that outperforms all previous solutions, in which case it would be accepted (this is the so-called aspiration criterion). TS has performed well on the QAP [9,10,151,154,190,191] and on the JSSP [159,165,166,183,225].

TSP In an instance of the *Traveling Salesperson Problem*, also known as *Traveling Salesman Problem*, a set of n cities or locations as well as the distances between them are given [4,95,127,131,208,216]. The goal is to find the shortest round-trip tour that starts at one city, visits all the other cities one time each, and returns to the origin. The TSP is one of the most well-known $\mathcal{NP}$-hard combinatorial optimization problems [83,95,123]. The TSP has many applications[4], including in transportation, logistics, (circuit) plotting and drilling problems[94], telescope aiming, and genome sequencing. Solutions are often encoded as permutations x of the first n natural numbers, where each city gets a number and the order of numbers in the permutation corresponds to the order of cities in the tour. The distances between the n cities are usually given in a $n \times n$ distance matrix A, where $A[a, b]$ is the distance from city a to city b with $a, b \in 1..n$. Then, the objective function subject to minimization is $f(x) = A[x_n, x_\mathbf{1}] + \sum_{i=\mathbf{1}}^{n-\mathbf{1}} A[x_i, x_{i+\mathbf{1}}]$. Typical benchmark instances can be found in TSPLib [175,176], the 8th DIMACS challenge[111–113], and the *World TSP* repository[46].

TSPLib is a library of benchmark instances for the Traveling Salesperson Problem (TSP) [175,176]. Its original URL was available until 2025 and then became defunct. The repository https://github.com/shredderzwj/TSPLIB contains the data. Additionally, you may also check https://github.com/thomasWeise/tspSuite, which contains all the TSPLib instances as well as Java code to load them. The TSPLib contains 110 instances of the symmetric Traveling Salesperson Problems (STSPs) with scales n ranging from 14 to 85 900, but 93 instances have less than 2000 nodes. There also are 19 asymmetric Traveling Salesperson Problems (ATSPs) with scales $n \in 17..443$.

Glossary XIII



TTP The *Traveling Tournament Problem* is the combinatorial optimization problem of both efficiently and fairly organizing a tournament of n teams that play against each other in a pairwise fashion [69,220]. The efficient part boils down to arranging the games such that the total travel length is short, which is somewhat similar to the classical TSP. Initially, each team is at its home location. On each day, a team needs to travel if its scheduled game is not at its present location. On the last day, each team may need to travel back home unless their last game is a home game. The total travel length sums up the lengths of all travels over all teams. The fair part is represented in several constraints, such as doubleRoundRobin, compactness, maxStreak, and noRepeat. The TTP is $\mathcal{NP}$-hard [201].

TwoMax The TwoMax problem is a benchmark problem for bit-string based black-box search [81,199,224]. It has a global and a local optimum, both of about the same size, at opposite ends of the search space. For bit strings of length n, the objective function $f(x)$ of the minimization variant is 0 if $\|x\|_1 = n$ and $1 + n - \max\{\|x\|_1, n - \|x\|_1\}$ otherwise, where $\|x\|_1 = \sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i$. An $(1+1)$ EA has a 50/50 chance to converge to the local or global optimum and thus has an expected runtime in $\Theta(n^n)$ [80,81]. In experiments, the $(1+1)$ FEA achieves polynomial runtime seemingly in $\mathcal{O}(n^2 \ln n)$ on TwoMax [214,215,224].

URI A *Uniform Resource Identifier* is an identifier for an abstract or physical resource in the internet [223]. It can be a URL, a name, or both. URIs are supersets of URLs. The connection strings of the PostgreSQL DBMS are examples of Uniform Resource Identifiers (URIs).

URL A *Uniform Resource Locator* identifies a resource in the World Wide Web (WWW) and a way to obtain it by describing a network access mechanism. The most notable example of URLs is the text you write into web browsers to visit websites [20]. URLs are subsets of URIs.

VND *Variable Neighborhood Descend*; see VNS. VND in combination with GRASP has been applied to the 2BP|O|F in [164].

Glossary XIV

VNS *Variable Neighborhood Search* is a metaheuristic framework combining a systematic change of neighborhood with LS [96,155]. A *neighborhood* structure in LS defines which solutions can be reached from a given solution within one search step. Usually, one uses a single unary operator and, hence, has a single neighborhood structure. However, for many problems, we can easily design many operators. For permutations, for example, one operator may swap two elements, another one may reverse a section of the permutation, and yet another one, while yet another one may rotate a subsequence one step to the left or right [208]. In the VNS framework, a multiple neighborhoods are investigated in a systematic fashion. Assume that we have a list of neighborhood structures. Variable Neighborhood Descend (VND) works in a deterministic fashion. It finds the best solution that can be reached in one step from the current solution under the current neighborhood. If this is better than the current solution, we accept it and continue with the first neighborhood. Otherwise, we continue with the next neighborhood in the list. In Basic VNS, instead of picking the best move from the current neighborhood, the first improving move is used. Also, at the beginning of each cycle, a random point from the current neighborhood around the current solution is chosen as starting point.

WWW World Wide Web [19,51]

$i!$ The factorial $a!$ of a natural number $a \in \mathbb{N}_{\mathbf{1}}$ is the product of all positive natural numbers less than or equal to a, i.e., $a! = 1 * 2 * 3 * 4 * \cdots * (a-1) * a$ [36,67,143].

$\circ^\star$ the superscript $\star$ symbol denotes that $\circ$ is a global optimum, i.e., there is no better solution than $\circ$.

$i..j$ with $i, j \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $i \leq j$ is the set that contains all integer numbers in the inclusive range from i to j. It always holds that $i..j \subset \mathbb{Z}$. For example, $5..9$ is equivalent to $\{5, 6, 7, 8, 9\}$

A the $n \times n$ distance matrix. $A[a, b]$ indicates the distance between locations a and b with $a, b \in 1..n$. A distance matrix can be symmetric, in which case $A[a, b] = A[b, a]\ \forall a, b \in 1..n$. Distance matrices represent the problem instance data in TSPs and part of the instance data of QAPs.

B the $n \times n$ flow matrix. $B[a, b]$ is the flow of goods between locations a and b with $a, b \in 1..n$. Flow matrices are one half of the problem instance data of QAPs.

Glossary XV

$f(y)$ The *objective function* $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$ can compute a cost or rating for each candidate solution y in the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$. The smaller this value, the better the solution, i.e., in the context of this work, objective functions are subject to minimization. Objective functions are not necessarily continuous and it is also quite common that they have integer or natural numbers as results, e.g., we often have $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{N}_0$ instead of $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$.

$\gamma(x)$ The decoding function $\gamma : \mathbb{X} \mapsto \mathbb{Y}$ translates point from the search space $\mathbb{X}$ to one point y in the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$. It is a very common case that $\mathbb{X} = \mathbb{Y}$ and that the decoding function γ is the identity mapping. Examples for encodings that translate from a simple search space $\mathbb{X}$ to a complex solution data structure $\mathbb{Y}$ are the IBL algorithm that translates (potentially signed) permutations to two-dimensional packings on the 2BP, the permutation-based encoding of Gantt charts for the JSSP from [22,23,84,181,209], or the permutation-based encoding of game plans for the TTP from [220]. Encodings can also translate between types of search spaces. The Random Keys encoding, for example, translates from $[0, 1]^n$ to permutations of the first n natural numbers..

k the number of jobs in an instance of the JSSP.

m the number of machines in an instance of the JSSP.

Glossary XVI

n We usually use the value $n \in \mathbb{N}_0$ to denote the *scale*, i.e., the size of the problem to solve. This notion is very general in computer science and not limited to optimization. For example, if we sort a list or search in a list, the scale n is the length of the list, i.e., the number of elements in it. In a TSP, this may be the number of cities. In a discrete benchmark problem such as OneMax or Trap, this may be the number of bits over which the problem is defined. In a QAP, this may be the number of facilities and locations. In a MaxSAT problem, this may be the number of variables that are input to the Boolean formula that we want to become true. There are also problems where the scale is not defined straightforwardly like this. For example, in a JSSP, we have a number of machines and a number of jobs, which together define the size of the problem. But even then, the scale n relates to the size of the solution space $\mathbb{Y}$, and, hence, also of the search space $\mathbb{X}$, which usually grow exponentially with n. And this is already the main issue: The larger n, the (exponentially) larger the number of possible solutions and thus, the larger the runtime of algorithms. This is known as the "curse of dimensionality" [17,38]. Scales n are also often used in conjunction with the $\mathcal{O}$-notation to denote algorithm complexity. For example, comparison-based sorting a list of n items takes $\boldsymbol{\Theta}(n \log n)$ steps [119] (because they need $\lceil \log_2 n! \rceil$ comparisons in the worst case).

$\mathbb{N}_0$ the set of the natural numbers *including* 0, i.e., 0, 1, 2, 3, and so on. It holds that $\mathbb{N}_0 \subset \mathbb{Z}$ and that $\mathbb{N}_0 = \mathbb{N}_1 \cup \{0\}$.

$\mathbb{N}_1$ the set of the natural numbers *excluding* 0, i.e., 1, 2, 3, 4, and so on. It holds that $\mathbb{N}_1 \subset \mathbb{Z}$ and that $\mathbb{N}_1 = \mathbb{N}_0 \setminus \{0\}$.

$\mathcal{NP}$ is the class of computational problems that can be solved in polynomial time by a non-deterministic machine and can be verified in polynomial time by a deterministic machine (such as a normal computer) [92].

$\mathcal{NP}$-complete A decision problem is $\mathcal{NP}$-complete if it is in $\mathcal{NP}$ and all problems in $\mathcal{NP}$ are reducible to it in polynomial time [92,173]. A problem is $\mathcal{NP}$-complete if it is $\mathcal{NP}$-hard and if it is in $\mathcal{NP}$.

$\mathcal{NP}$-hard A problem is $\mathcal{NP}$-hard if all problems in $\mathcal{NP}$ are reducible to it in polynomial time [92]. Algorithms that guarantee to find the correct solutions of $\mathcal{NP}$-hard problems [37,43,126] have a worst-case runtime that grows exponentially with the problem scale.

$\boldsymbol{\Omega}(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \boldsymbol{\Omega}(g(x))$, then there exist positive numbers $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $f(x) \geq c * g(x) \geq 0$ for all $x \geq x_0$ [47,117,118]. In other words, $\boldsymbol{\Omega}(g(x))$ describes a lower bound for function growth.

$\mathcal{O}(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \mathcal{O}(g(x))$, then there exist positive numbers $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $0 \leq f(x) \leq c * g(x)$ for all $x \geq x_0$ [6,47,117,118,124]. In other words, $\mathcal{O}(g(x))$ describes an upper bound for function growth.

Glossary XVII



$\Theta(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \Theta(g(x))$, then $f(x) = \mathcal{O}(g(x))$ and $f(x) = \Omega(g(x))$ [117,118], meaning that there exist positive constants $c_1, c_2, x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $0 \leq c_1 g(x) \leq f(x) \leq c_2 g(x)$ for all $x \geq x_0$ [47]. In other words, $\Theta(g(x))$ describes an exact order of function growth.

$o(g(x))$ If $f(x) = o(g(x))$, then there exist positive numbers $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $0 \leq f(x) \leq c * g(x)$ for all $x \geq x_0$ *all* $c \in \mathbb{R}^+$ [47]. Different from $\mathcal{O}(g(x))$, $o(g(x))$ holds for *all* constants $c > 0$, whereas $\mathcal{O}(g(x))$ implies the existence of *some* constant $c > 0$. This basically means that $f(x)$ becomes insignificant compared to $g(x)$ as x_0 grows toward infinity. It is often written that $\lim_{x_0 \to \infty} \frac{f(x)}{g(x)} = 0$. In other words, $o(g(x))$ describes an upper bound for function growth that is not asymptotically tight, i.e., an upper bound that grows faster than $f(x)$.

$\mathbb{R}$ the set of the real numbers.

$\mathbb{R}^+$ the set of the positive real numbers, i.e., $\mathbb{R}^+ = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x > 0\}$.

$\omega(g(x))$ If $f(x) = \omega(g(x))$, then for every positive constant $c > 0$, there exists a number $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^+$ such that $0 \leq c * g(x) < f(x)$ for all $x \geq x_0$ [47]. In other words, $f(x) = \omega(g(x))$ if and only if $g(x) = o(f(x))$. In other words, ω describes a lower bound that is not asymptotically tight.

$\mathbb{Y}$ the set of candidate solutions of an optimization problem is called the *solution space* $\mathbb{Y}$. The solution space corresponds to the data structure holding the candidate solutions y. These are the elements that are passed to the user after the optimization process is completed. They are also the parameters of the objective function(s) $f : \mathbb{Y} \mapsto \mathbb{R}$.

y a candidate solution $y \in \mathbb{Y}$ is one possible solution to an optimization problem. After the optimization process is completed, one or multiple such solutions are passed to the user.

$\mathbb{Z}$ the set of the integers numbers including positive and negative numbers and 0, i.e., . . . , -3, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, 3, . . . , and so on. It holds that $\mathbb{Z} \subset \mathbb{R}$.